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Operating System Updates, Patching and Restart Issues

Failed updates, forced restarts, compliance warnings, drivers and update rings

Default priority: P3 Medium
(P2 if many devices are affected)

Target response / resolution: Respond in 30 min / resolve in 4 business hours

Handled by: Tier 2, then Endpoint team

Scope

Use this instruction when a device fails to install updates, restarts unexpectedly, is flagged non-compliant for missing patches, or has problems after an update.

Related instructions: WI-03 Laptops and Peripherals, WI-04 Software, WI-10 Security Incidents

Common symptoms

- Update stuck or fails with an error code
- Device keeps asking to restart
- Device flagged as non-compliant for missing updates
- Problems started right after an update
- Update takes too long or uses too much bandwidth

Information to collect

- Hostname, operating system version, and build number
- Update name or KB number, and the error code
- When the update started, and how long the device has been up
- Whether other devices have the same issue

Resolution steps

- 1 Check the scope.** Check the update management console. If many devices fail the same update, treat it as a possible bad release, stop the rollout, and escalate to the Endpoint team.
- 2 Check the basics.** Check free disk space (at least 15 GB is a good minimum), battery or power, and the network connection. Restart the device to complete any pending update.
- 3 Review the error.** Look at the update history and the error code. Search the knowledge base and the vendor documentation for the code.
- 4 Run the built-in troubleshooter.** Run the update troubleshooter, reset the update components, and check the system file integrity. Retry the installation.
- 5 Clear a blocked update.** Check for third-party security tools, VPN, or proxy that block the update. Install the update manually from the update catalogue if needed.
- 6 Roll back if necessary.** If the device is unstable after an update, uninstall the update or restore from a restore point. Pause the update on that device and report to the Endpoint team.
- 7 Confirm compliance.** Check the device reports as compliant in the console. Tell the user when to restart and how to schedule restarts outside working time.

Escalate when

- Many devices fail the same update
- Update causes data loss, boot failure, or business application faults
- Critical security patches cannot be installed within the required timeframe

Resolution and closure

- Record the update, the error code, and the fix
- Report any bad updates to the patch management owner
- Close after the device is compliant and the user confirms it works normally

Quick troubleshooting reference

Symptom	Likely cause	What to do
Update stuck at a percentage	Low disk space, or corrupted download	Free space, restart, reset update components, and retry.
Error code 0x80070002 or similar	Missing or damaged update files	Clear the update cache and run the troubleshooter.
Device restarts at bad times	No active hours or deadlines set	Set active hours through policy, and explain the restart schedule.
Non-compliant for patches	Offline too long, or update blocked	Connect to the network, run a sync, and install pending updates.
Application fails after an update	Compatibility issue	Check known issues, roll back the update if approved, and report to the application owner.

Suggested wording for the user

Open	<i>"Updates keep our devices safe, so I want to get this one installed properly. When did you last restart your laptop?"</i>
During	<i>"I am clearing a stuck download and retrying the update. Please keep the laptop plugged in and connected."</i>
Close	<i>"The update is installed and your device shows as up to date. Please restart weekly so updates can complete."</i>

Good practice

Do

- Check disk space and power first
- Report widespread failures immediately
- Use update rings to test before wide release
- Explain why updates matter

Do not

- Do not tell users to turn off updates
- Do not delete system files by hand
- Do not skip security patches without approval
- Do not force restarts without warning during working hours

Worked example

Twelve laptops fail a monthly cumulative update with the same error code.

Ticket note field	Entry
Issue reported	Several users report the update fails at 30 percent, then rolls back.
Checks performed	Console shows 12 failures in the pilot ring, all with the same error. All have a recent security agent version.
Cause	Conflict between the update and the older security agent.
Action taken	Paused the rollout to later rings. Endpoint team updated the security agent and redeployed.
Result	Updates installed successfully. Rollout resumed with the corrected agent.

Frequently asked questions

Q. Can users postpone updates indefinitely?

No. Allow a short deferral, then enforce. Delayed updates leave security gaps and cause compliance failures.

Q. An update has broken an application. Do we uninstall it?

Check with the Endpoint team first. If agreed, roll back on affected devices, pause the update for that ring, and log a problem record.

Q. How do we explain restarts to users?

Say that updates only finish after a restart, and set active hours and a weekly restart habit to avoid disruption.

Analyst checklist

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| ☐ Check the scope | ☐ Roll back if necessary |
| ☐ Check the basics | ☐ Confirm compliance |
| ☐ Review the error | ☐ Ticket note completed using the standard template |
| ☐ Run the built-in troubleshooter | ☐ User confirmed the issue is resolved |
| ☐ Clear a blocked update | |

Preventing repeat tickets

- Use staged rollout rings with pilot groups
- Keep disk space alerts in place
- Keep security and device agents current
- Publish the restart and update schedule to users